

THE ART OF THE DRY FLY

2-Day Curriculum · Student Handout

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14 Sessions	~9 hrs On-water time	7 Skill pillars	2 Full days
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Leader Building · Presentation Casting · Active & Passive Floats · Mending · Rise Forms · Fly Selection · Stealth & Approach

"Instructional methods for the art of dry fly fishing are becoming a thing of the past for most anglers. The important tasks to develop — observation, precise casting, drift control, and reading the rise — are what we are here to recover."

macbrownflyfish.com · flyfishingguideschool.com

Quick reference

RISE FORMS — WHAT THE FISH IS TELLING YOU

Sip	Gentle ring, nose through surface film — upwinged dun or spinner. Selective, rhythmic.
Slash	Aggressive, splashy take — caddis escaping the surface. React quickly; fish is chasing.
Porpoise roll	Dorsal fin then tail, no nose — fish taking emergers just subsurface. Try a cripple or soft-hackle.
Boil / bulge	Hump of water, no break of surface — subsurface nymph. Not a dry fly moment.
Spotted ring	Circular ring with small air bubbles — spent spinner trapped in the film. Match with film pattern.
Sucking rise	Classical ring with a bubble — upwinged dun fully on surface. Dead drift is essential.
Compound rise	Fish drifts under fly, inspects, then sips or refuses — patience; fix drift before changing fly.
Leap / crash	Full body out of water — large terrestrial or big stonefly. Match the silhouette and skitter it.

FLOAT STYLES — PASSIVE TO ACTIVE

Dead drift (passive)	Fly leads all line and leader. No drag. Matches duns, spinners, trapped emergers.
Twitch	Rod-tip hammer: 1 inch of movement. Triggers caddis and stonefly interest. One flick, then pause.
Skitter	3–4 fast side-to-side rod pulses: fly dances cross-current. Caddis behavior imitation.
Skate	Sustained rod-high cross-current movement. Pool tails and smooth fast slicks. No V-wake.
High-stick wiggle	Rod at 11 o'clock, strip while wiggling tip. Close-quarters active drift, line off water.

FLY STYLE BY WATER TYPE

Pocket water & fast ripples	High-floating attractors: Royal Wulff, Stimulator, Humpy, Elk Hair Caddis #10–#16
Run seams	Convertible patterns: Parachute Adams, Klinkhämer, Convertible Caddis #12–#18
Glassy flats & pools	Precise imitations: CDC Dun, Sparkle Dun, Comparadun, Spinner #14–#22
Pool tails & smooth tailouts	Low-riding emergers & cripples: CDC Emerger, Rim Chung RS2, Barr Emerger #16–#22
Terrestrial season	Foam patterns: Chernobyl Ant, Hopper, Beetle, Inchworm #8–#14 — skitter or twitch
When nothing hatches	Search with attractor; watch for any rise; downsize and go to film pattern if selective

REFUSAL RESPONSE HIERARCHY — FIX DRIFT BEFORE CHANGING FLY

1	Adjust drift	Lengthen tippet, change cast angle, add aerial mend — drag is the most common refusal cause.
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2	Extend tippet	Add 12–18" of finer tippet — reduce leader shadow and improve S-curve formation.
3	Downsize fly	Drop one or two hook sizes — silhouette is often closer than color.
4	Change stage	Switch emerger → dun → spinner or vice versa — are you matching the right life stage?
5	Change pattern	Last resort. If stage, size, and drift are right, a different pattern rarely solves the problem.

HARVEY LEADER FORMULA — BUTT TO TIPPET

Butt section	60% of total length	0X–1X (.011"–.010")	Stiff nylon; carries energy from fly line
Mid taper	25% of total length	2X–3X (.009"–.008")	Transition; blood knots throughout
Tippet section	15% of total length	4X–6X (.007"–.005")	Soft nylon only — never fluorocarbon for dries
Extended tippet	Add 12–24" as needed	6X–7X for flats	Buys extra S-curve and reduces leader visibility

Mac's note on leader philosophy

The issue with traditional formulas is that they were developed for gut leaders, which were standard until around 1939. Many popular leader formulas carry ideology that belongs to that era — before mono moved the sport forward. Monofilament itself has improved dramatically since the original DuPont materials of the early years.

By example: Maxima Chameleon has been my preference since childhood for building taper sections. Nothing on the market matches its stiffness per diameter, which is what actually controls turnover. It has been the most consistently popular choice among serious anglers since the early 1950s for good reason.

M B The real question when building a leader is this: should a leader transfer energy or dissipate it? If you want to turn over a big bushy dry fly, you want energy transfer — a stiffer, more powerful taper. If you want to land a small CDC or Parachute pattern with a soft pile of tippet, you want energy dissipation — a longer, finer, more supple taper. No one leader does both equally well. Understanding that distinction is more valuable than memorizing any single formula.

For 80% of the fishing in my region, I prefer far and fine leaders over all other configurations. The general-utility Harvey formula in the table above is a useful starting point — but it is a starting point, not a final answer.

There are knots easier to tie and more reliable than the standard blood knot and surgeon's knot. There are specialty formulas for specific conditions that will transform how you fish. I have compiled leader construction resources on my website that go deep on all of this:

macbrownflyfish.com/blog/learn-leader-construction/

OAR STROKE SEQUENCE — NEVER SKIP THE ORDER

1. Catch Blade enters cleanly, arms relaxed, shins vertical	2. Drive Legs push first, then back opens, then arms pull	3. Finish Arms drawn to lower chest, handle down to extract blade	4. Recovery Arms → body → legs in reverse; slow and controlled
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Day 1 — Foundation & the drift7:30 – 8:30 am **Welcome, philosophy & the lost art conversation**

PHILOSOPHY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why dry fly mastery is declining in modern fly fishing
- Establish the instructor approach: observation before presentation
- Distinguish attractor fishing from true hatch-matching
- Set personal goals for the two days

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Attractor vs. imitation spectrum ◆ Observation as the first cast ◆ Hatch-matching tradition ◆ Southern Appalachian dry fly heritage ◆ Why nymph-first culture displaced the dry

ACTIVITIES

- Group discussion: when did you last fool a rising fish on a dry? What stopped you?
- Brief history: Halford, Marinaro, Harvey — the lineage of dry fly thinking
- Instructor demonstration: 5 minutes of bankside observation before a single cast is thrown

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"The cast itself needs to be honed for the surroundings. Most fly anglers I knew growing up in the 1970s and 80s were die-hard dry fly anglers — attractor patterns, specific hatch matches. That culture is what we are recovering here."

8:30 – 10:00
am**Leader building — taper, diameter & the drag equation**

LEADER

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build a hand-tied leader understanding taper design principles
- Understand butt-to-tippet energy transfer and what diameter controls
- Match tippet size to fly size
- Distinguish nylon vs. fluorocarbon for surface presentation

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Energy transfer vs. energy dissipation — the governing leader question ◆ Stiffness per diameter — what actually controls turnover ◆ 4X–7X for dry flies size #10–#22 ◆ Nylon monofilament floats; fluorocarbon sinks — always nylon for dries ◆ Far and fine leaders for Appalachian conditions ◆ No single leader formula works for all situations

ACTIVITIES

- Bench session: students build a leader from component spools using today's target water type as the brief
- Turnover test on flat water — does the leader lay straight or collapse softly into a pile?
- Tippet matching exercise: pair six fly sizes to correct tippet diameter
- Discuss energy transfer vs. dissipation: big bushy dries vs. small CDC patterns — which leader serves each?

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"At the heart of every good leader is an intentional balance between energy transfer and the presentation you need. The Harvey formula is a starting point — but understanding why it works, and when to depart from it, is the real skill. See the leader construction resources in the quick reference section."

✓

Checkpoint: Each student casts their built leader; instructor checks turnover — does it unfurl cleanly and lay soft tippet on the water? No leader advances to water work that cannot demonstrate a controlled delivery suited to the target presentation.

10:00 – 10:15
am*Break & walk to water*10:15 am –
12:00 pm**Casting for better drifts — aerial mends & presentation**

CASTING

casts

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why aerial mends outperform post-landing mends for dry flies
- Execute reach cast, pile cast, and curve casts on both sides
- Throw a slack-line S-curve wiggle cast for complex multi-current situations
- Apply single-handed Spey casts for tight-cover direction changes

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Aerial mend vs. post-landing mend ◆ Reach cast: rod tip swings upstream during forward cast ◆ Pile/puddle cast: controlled collapse for instant slack on target ◆ Curve cast positive and negative: banking around obstacles ◆ S-curve wiggle cast: rod-tip oscillation during delivery ◆ Sidearm and steeple for overhanging cover ◆ Single-handed Spey: snap-T and circle-C for direction changes ◆ Upstream vs. downstream cast geometry

ACTIVITIES

- Flat-water drill: each cast type 10 times — reach, pile, curve left, curve right
- Moving to a riffle: cast to a target across a current seam — which cast solves it?
- Spey practice: limited backcast scenarios in streamside brush
- Paired observation: student A casts, student B watches leader behavior and calls drag onset

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B

"To do this in its purest form means mastering curve and pile casts for all casting planes. Change-of-direction casts matched to dynamic currents where trout actually hold — this is where the art lives."

✓

Checkpoint: Each student completes a 3-cast sequence: reach cast across a seam, pile cast to a pool, and a direction-change Spey from a confined bank position. Instructor assesses whether the tippet leads or lags the fly.

12:00 – 12:45
pm

Lunch on the river

12:45 – 2:30
pm

Active vs. passive floats — reading what the fly should do

PRESENTATION

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Distinguish when a dead drift serves vs. when movement triggers strikes
- Execute a twitch, skitter, and full skate with appropriate insects
- Match float style to the natural's behavior on the water
- Understand why the V-wake kills a presentation and how to avoid it

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Passive float: fly leads all line and leader — no drag ◆ Active float: twitch (1 in.), skitter (3–4 pulses), skate (sustained cross-current) ◆ V-wake: the drag signature that betrays an artificial ◆ Caddis = skitter and skate; mayfly dun = passive dead drift ◆ Stonefly skimming, grasshoppers kicking — match action to insect ◆ Pool tail fast slick: ideal skating water ◆ Dead drift to skitter transition — reset after drift, don't lift early ◆ High-stick wiggle for close water without line on the surface

ACTIVITIES

- Calm eddy: practice twitching a hopper — rod-tip hammer technique, 1-inch rule
- Pool tail: skate a caddis pattern across the slick — no V-wake enforced by partner
- Riffle-to-flat transition: read the water, choose passive or active, execute and debrief
- Rotation: each student fishes 30-ft stretch, then observes partner and critiques float style

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"I am not advocating always fishing dries — but fly fishers should become adept at perfecting their dry fly game for a richer experience overall. The ability to control the fly's behavior, not just its landing, separates a good dry fly angler from a great one."

✓

Checkpoint: Each student correctly identifies passive or active float for two different water types, then executes without creating a V-wake on active presentations. Instructor watches for V-wake and slack management.

2:30 – 4:00 pm **Day 1 debrief, rise form introduction & stream observation**

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Consolidate leader, casting, and float concepts from the day
- Introduce rise form vocabulary before applying it on Day 2
- Practice bankside observation without a rod in hand
- Preview Day 2: mending, fly selection, rise reading on live water

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Sip: gentle ring, nose through film — dun or emerger ◆ Slash: aggressive, caddis-chasing behavior ◆ Porpoise roll: dorsal-then-tail — emerger just subsurface ◆ Boil/bulge: subsurface take, not a surface rise ◆ Spotted ring with bubbles: spinner in the film ◆ Sucking rise: classical ring with bubble — upwinged dun

ACTIVITIES

- 15 minutes of silent bankside observation — instructor names rise types, students call them
- Rise form photo quiz: 10 images, students match form to likely food source
- Self-assessment: leader turnover, aerial mend execution, float control
- Preview Day 2 water plan and hatch timing window



Checkpoint: Students correctly identify at least 5 of 8 rise form images and can describe what each suggests about feeding stage before Day 2 begins.

Day 2 — Enticement & mastery

7:30 – 8:30 am

Reading rise forms on live water — observation before the cast

RISE FORMS

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify sip, slash, porpoise, boil, sucking rise, and spotted-ring rises in real current
- Determine feeding stage from the rise form alone before selecting a fly
- Position correctly before selecting a pattern
- Understand the compound rise and why fish inspect and refuse

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Sip = dun or spinner; nose protrudes through film ◆ Slash = caddis, fast escape behavior ◆ Porpoise roll = emerger; dorsal-fin-then-tail, no nose ◆ Boil/bulge = subsurface nymph; not a dry fly moment ◆ Spotted ring with bubbles = spent spinner in the film ◆ Compound rise: fish drifts under fly, inspects, sips or refuses ◆ Count: watch 3 rises before deciding on fly stage

ACTIVITIES

- Walk the bank: 20-minute observation-only exercise — no rods, students record rise type and suspected food
- Instructor-led discussion at each rise: 'What does this fish tell us?'
- First cast challenge: approach one rising fish, observe 3 rises, then make one presentation — grade the fly choice



Checkpoint: Each student correctly diagnoses feeding stage for a live rising fish before selecting a fly. Instructor validates the call before the student casts.

8:30 – 10:15 am

Mending for enticement — line control beyond the dead drift

MENDING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute upstream, downstream, and reach mend without disturbing the fly
- Use S-curve and upstream belly to buy extra drift time
- Apply a downstream slack-line presentation for fish above your position
- Understand when mending ends and intentional skating begins

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Upstream mend: flip line belly upstream — slows fly in fast current ◆ Downstream mend: speeds fly in slow water to match current ◆ Reach mend: done in the air, not after landing — the dry fly ideal ◆ Pile mend: controlled slack dump on target for maximum initial drift ◆ S-curve/C-curve: rod-tip writing during delivery ◆ Downstream presentation: fly arrives before tippet on glassy water ◆ High-rod stack mend: feeding line for extended big-water drifts ◆ Mend timing: earlier and farther than instinct suggests

ACTIVITIES

- Seam drill: cast across a current seam — student achieves 15-second drift without mending, then with
- Downstream presentation: from above, drop fly to a feeding fish in a flat pool using slack-line cast
- Complex multi-current drill: cross three current lanes — student identifies which mend applies at each stage
- Partner observation: call out the first moment of drag — teaches precision and timing feedback



"Change-of-direction casts and curve casts for all casting planes give you the ability to manage the drift before it starts. The mend is your insurance — but the aerial cast is your best weapon."



Checkpoint: Each student achieves a minimum 12-second drag-free drift across a current seam using only aerial mends and one post-landing correction. Instructor times.

10:15 – 10:30 am

Break

10:30 am –
12:00 pm**Matching fly styles to water type — attractor to imitation spectrum**

FLY SELECTION

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Match fly style and profile to five water types
- Understand when attractor logic outperforms imitation and vice versa
- Identify key Southern Appalachian hatches and their classic matches
- Apply the silhouette-first, then size, then color selection hierarchy

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Pocket water & riffles: Wulff, Stimulator, Humpy, Elk Hair Caddis ◆ Run seams: Parachute Adams, Klinkhämer, Convertible ◆ Glassy flats: CDC Dun, Sparkle Dun, Comparadun, Griffith's Gnat ◆ Pool tails: CDC Emerger, cripples, RS2 ◆ Appalachian hatches: BWO, Yellow Sallies, March Brown, Quill Gordon, Sulfur ◆ Silhouette first, size second, color last in selection hierarchy ◆ Floatant: gel before first cast, powder after fish, Amadou for drying

ACTIVITIES

- Fly box sort: students organize by water type, not hatch — instructor reviews logic
- Local hatch chart review: what is likely on the water today and what is the best match?
- Two-fly comparison drill: fish same rise lane with attractor and imitation — which gets more looks?
- Bankside: instructor identifies a hatch in progress, students select a fly and justify before casting

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"Most fly anglers I knew growing up were die-hard about attractor patterns or specific hatch matches. The wisdom is knowing which logic the fish is operating on right now — not defaulting to one approach all the time."

✓

Checkpoint: Each student selects the correct style category for three different water types and justifies the choice. Instructor validates before the student fishes the fly.

12:00 – 12:45
pm

Lunch

12:45 – 2:30
pm**Stealth, approach & the complete presentation sequence**

APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Approach a rising fish without detection
- Execute a complete presentation sequence: observe → position → select → cast → drift → respond
- Manage refusals intelligently — fix drift before changing fly
- Understand the compound rise and patience as an active technique

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Approach from below and to the side; never upstream of a sighted fish ◆ Shadow awareness: rod flash, clothing silhouette, step-wave disturbance ◆ Upstream approach: angler in trout's blind spot ◆ Downstream presentation: fly arrives before tippet on flat water ◆ First cast is best cast — plan it; don't rush it ◆ Refusal response: drift → tippet → size → stage → pattern ◆ Patience: allow 10–15 minutes for fish to reset after disturbance ◆ Reading the feeding lane: your fly must enter the exact slot

ACTIVITIES

- Stalking exercise: approach a visible rising fish using heron-walk technique — instructor grades the approach
- Full sequence run: locate, observe, plan, approach, select, cast, drift — one fish at a time with coaching
- Refusal drill: after a refusal, diagnose the cause and choose the correct adjustment before recasting
- Rotation: each student targets an independent rising fish; peers observe and debrief

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"We offer private wade trips for learning this on the stream — no doubt one of the quickest methods for improvement. The observation piece is what most people skip. The best cast you will ever make is the one you waited to throw."

✓

Checkpoint: Each student completes a full presentation sequence on a rising fish — from bankside observation to a drag-free drift over the fish's feeding lane. Instructor grades on stealth, fly selection logic, cast execution, and drift quality.

2:30 – 4:00 pm **Final debrief, individual assessment & the path forward**

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Synthesize the two-day arc from leader building to live fish
- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one technical and one observational priority to develop
- Build a personal 30-day practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: leader turnover, aerial mend, float control, rise reading, fly selection, approach
- Individual feedback: one technical strength, one priority, one thing to practice on every outing
- Recommended resources: Marinaro's A Modern Dry-Fly Code, Harvey on leaders, local hatch charts
- Personal 30-day practice plan: specific water, specific skill, observation journal prompt



Checkpoint: Completed written assessment returned to each student. Instructor retains copy for program records.